Terms of Reference

Executive Steering Committee
Decade of Action for Cryospheric Sciences (2025–2034)

I. Background

On August 13, 2024, the United Nations General Assembly adopted Resolution 78/321, proclaiming 2025 to 2034 as the Decade of Action for Cryospheric Sciences. The resolution aims to accelerate efforts to address the urgent challenges posed by the melting cryosphere through enhanced scientific research, monitoring, and international cooperation. The resolution highlights the need to understand the cryosphere's role in the Earth's climate system, freshwater resources, ecosystems, and human social, political, and economic activities. It also calls for raising awareness of cryospheric loss and encourages the sharing of best practices to build resilience against related risks. Member States, UN bodies, and stakeholders are invited to support these activities. UNESCO is tasked with leading implementation of the Decade, with other UN organizations and partners, using voluntary contributions to develop programmes.

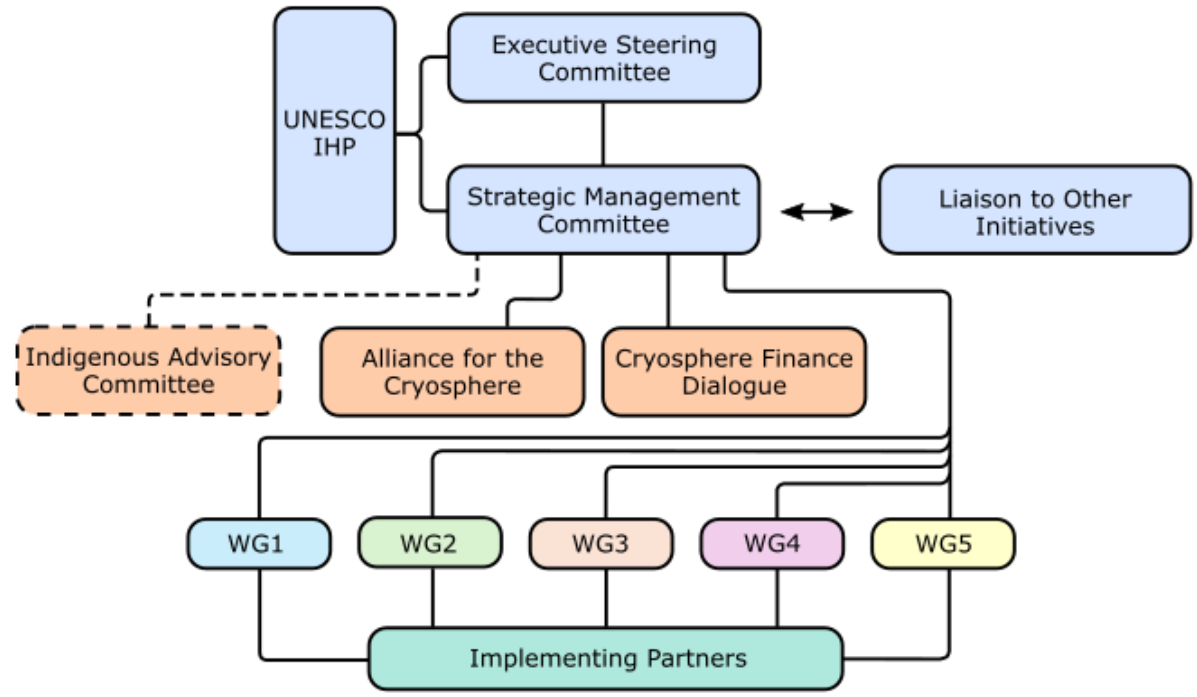
During the first year of the Decade, 2025, an Ad Hoc Committee was formed by UNESCO to form the structures necessary to implement the Decade. These are summarised in a **Synthesis Document**, which outlines the vision for the Decade. As a result of this process, the committee identified five Overarching Challenges (OC) for the Decade:

OC1. Global Cryosphere Monitoring
OC2 Actionable Cryosphere Projections
OC3 Cryospheric Risk Management Solutions
OC4 Adaptation to Cryosphere Loss
OC5 Amplify the Impact of Cryospheric Science

Within the Decade, Working Groups aligned with each OC serve as the *main engines of delivery*. The Synthesis Document calls for an **Executive Steering Committee (ESC),** composed of Member States, which mobilises political will and provides strategic direction. Its role is to guide the Decade's legitimacy, positioning, and long-range coherence, without operational responsibilities or legal responsibility.

A tangible outcome of the Decade's vision is the creation of a Cryosphere Intelligence Platform. Progress towards goals and alignment with the overall vision will be reviewed at Triennial Cryosphere Summits.

The following diagram shows the structure of the Decade and the connexions to the ESC.



II. Objectives of the Executive Steering Committee

The Executive Steering Committee (ESC) will provide political and strategic oversight for the Decade, with the aim of mobilising political will and supporting intergovernmental engagement on cryosphere priorities. Membership will be composed of Member States with stakes in the cryosphere and influence advocates, relevant UN agencies and scientific organizations

The ESC will provide high-level guidance to support the Decade's ability to translate cryospheric science into decision-ready intelligence, including through strategic oversight of the Cryosphere Intelligence Platform as a core legacy mechanism of the Decade, and through political stewardship of the Triennial Cryosphere Summits as the main stocktaking moments of the Decade cycle.

III. Mandate and deliverables

The ESC will:

1. Provide political and strategic oversight of the Decade, supporting intergovernmental engagement and visibility, and mobilising political will among Member States.
2. Endorse Decade-wide strategic priorities and major governance arrangements, including transitions between Decade phases separated by Triennial Summits (foundations, operationalisation, policy and legacy).
3. Provide political stewardship of the Triennial Cryosphere Summits as the Decade's main progress review and alignment milestones and endorse high-level outcomes from these Summits.
4. Provide strategic oversight of the Cryosphere Intelligence Platform, including its governance orientation on transparency, provenance, explicit communication of uncertainty, decision-relevance, ethical integration of Indigenous and local knowledge, accessibility, interoperability, and sustainability beyond the Decade.
5. Endorse the appointment of the Strategic Management Committee (SMC) Chair, aligned with the agreed governance model where the SMC Chair is appointed by the ESC and IHP, and where the SMC Chair serves as ex officio on the ESC.

6. Receive strategic reporting from the Strategic Management Committee, which coordinates the five Working Groups, cross-cutting themes, and liaison with other initiatives, and reports to the Executive Steering Committee and IHP.
7. Uphold the Decade's scientific and ethical boundaries.

IV. Structure

A. Membership

Membership in the Executive Steering Committee shall be for a term aligned with the Triennial Cryosphere Summit cycle. The composition of the Committee shall be reviewed and, as appropriate, renewed following each Triennial Cryosphere Summit.
The Executive Steering Committee shall be composed as follows:

1. Member States (6)
Six Member States, one nominated from each UNESCO Electoral Group, ensuring geographic balance for 3-year cycle. Only one Member State per region shall serve at any given time.

2. United Nations system representatives (3)
- World Meteorological Organization (WMO)
- United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP)
- Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO)

3. Scientific organizations (3)
Three representatives from international scientific or professional organizations with recognized expertise in cryospheric sciences or closely related fields.

B. Chairmanship

The Executive Steering Committee shall be co-chaired by:
- A representative of one Member State serving on the Committee
- A representative of the Director-General of UNESCO as entrusted by the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) as the lead agency

The co-chairs act jointly to ensure alignment between intergovernmental leadership and UNESCO's coordinating mandate.

C. Ex officio participants (non-voting)

The following bodies shall participate ex officio, ensuring institutional coherence and coordination:
- Chair of the Strategic Management Committee
- Chair or designated representative of the Indigenous Advisory Committee
- Lead of the Alliance for the Cryosphere
- Lead of the Cryosphere Finance Dialogue

V. Modus Operandi

- The Executive Steering Committee will meet at least twice per year (virtually or in-person), with additional sessions as required.
- UNESCO-IHP will serve as the Secretariat and facilitate communication, documentation, and logistical support, in line with its implementing agency role.
- The Chair representing the Member States will be nominated during the Committee's first meeting.
- Drafts will be circulated in advance of each meeting, and decisions will be made by consensus.

- Committee members will be expected to consult their respective constituencies and networks in preparation for meetings.

VI. Coordination with other Decade bodies

The Executive Steering Committee provides political and strategic oversight and does not manage operations. Operational coordination and delivery functions sit within the Strategic Management Committee, Working Groups, and Secretariat as defined in the governance framework.

The Strategic Management Committee coordinates:

- the five Working Groups delivering the Main Goals of OC1–OC5
- cross-cutting themes (including finance and education)
- liaison with other related initiatives, and reports to the ESC and IHP

VII. Website

The Committee's proceedings, consultation summaries, and interim deliverables will be published on the Decade's official website: www.un-cryosphere.org/